Vaeira 5783

They say that practice makes perfect. מסירות נפש is something that has characterized the Jewish nation since its very beginning. For so many millions of Jews throughout history - in Europe, Russia, Spain, and elsewhere - it tragically was a physical experience. Fortunately, for us it is not. How can we practice for this important and חשובה concept?

It's my מנהג to have four things in mind when I say קריאת שמע in the morning. Right before שמע at הבוחר בעמו ישראל באהבה, I pause for a moment and think about these four things. The first concept is קבלת עול מלכות שמים, which is the primary כוונה of שמע. The second is מסירות נפש for קבלת עול מלכות שמים - I accept upon myself the willingness to be מוסר נפש for קבלת עול מלכות שמים. The third is the מצוה of קריאת שמע, both שחרית and ערבית, fulfilling the מצוה of קריאת שמע itself. The last concept, which I learned later in life, is to aspire to the כוונות of the דורות הקדמונים. I don't claim to reach their מדרגה, but I strive to connect with their כוונות in some way, to elevate my קריאת שמע through that aspiration. These thoughts help me focus on the idea of מסירות נפש and remind me of the dedication required for kiddush Hashem.

Where do we see an example of מסירות נפש in פרשת וארא? The pasuk says (7:28): וְשָׁרַץ הַיְאֹר צְפַרְדְּעִים וְעָלוּ וּבָאוּ בְּבֵיתֶךָ וּבַחֲדַר מִשְׁכָּבְךָ וְעַל מִטָּתֶךָ וּבְבֵית עֲבָדֶיךָ וּבְעַמֶּךָ וּבְתַנּוּרֶיךָ וּבְמִשְׁאֲרֹתֶיךָ. The מדרש, quoted in גמרא פסחים נ"ג ע"ב, connects this to חנניה, מישאל, ועזריה, who were מוסר נפש על קידוש השם and allowed themselves to be thrown into the כבשן האש. The גמרא explains that they made a קל וחומר from the צפרדעים: If the צפרדעים, who were not commanded in kiddush Hashem, jumped into the ovens as the pasuk describes, then certainly we, who are commanded in kiddush Hashem, must be מוסר נפש for Hashem's honor.

The שאגת אריה poses a קשיא on this קל וחומר. He asks, how can we say that the צפרדעים were not מצווֶה when the pasuk explicitly commands them וְעָלוּ וּבָאוּ? The גר"א, who was only seven years old at the time, offered a תירוץ to this קשיא: True, the צפרדעים were commanded to enter the houses, but they were not specifically commanded to jump into the ovens. Each frog could have avoided the תנור and chosen a bed or another location. Yet, they chose to demonstrate מסירות נפש by racing to the תנורים. That's the element from which חנניה, מישאל, ועזריה made the קל וחומר - that the צפרדעים went beyond their explicit ציווי out of a desire to sanctify Hashem's name. The שאגת אריה was so impressed with this answer that, according to the story, he picked up the young גר"א and kissed him on the forehead.

What is the takeaway? Each of us must strive in our own lives to seize opportunities for kiddush Hashem, whether through positive actions or, if necessary, through מסירות נפש. This is how we demonstrate our dedication to our בורא and bring Him נחת.

While I have your attention, I want to address a famous קשיא related to פרעה, unrelated to the above. If וַיְחַזֵּק ה' אֶת לֵב פַּרְעֹה - Hashem hardened פרעה's heart - how could he be punished for not allowing בני ישראל to leave? This is a monumental מחלוקת among the מפרשים, but I've always been drawn to the בית הלוי's תירוץ. Hashem didn't remove פרעה's free will; rather, He restored it. When פרעה was ready to release בני ישראל out of fear of the מכות, Hashem strengthened his heart to remove that fear, giving him the ability to choose freely. Without the coercion of fear, פרעה chose to persist in his defiance. So that's a fantastic תירוץ for this very fundamental קשיא of בחירה חפשית.

https://youtu.be/lYe1hk8OTmk